Dirty Dimes

By Mike McGee

INTRODUCTION

In an era when people routinely ask "What would Jesus do?" how many of us really practice what is preached? How many of us go the extra mile just because it's the right thing to do? If you really embrace the idea that we should treat others as we would like to be treated, test yourself the next time you're in the position to lend a hand. Will you be that person who is too busy, thinking the next person will take care of it? Let's take a minute to hold a mirror up to our behavior. The question is will you be happy with the reflection you see. It's about our ability to connect with people we don't know. To care about them and worry about them and imagine ourselves in their shoes. Dirty Dimes by Mike McGee

I'm wide awake as I stock the candy aisle in this late-night drugstore

My bell rings and I head toward my cash register

Two women

Barely thirty

Looking for a cashier

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Make eye contact with me and wait for my slow legs to reach them

My eyes are drawn to their items

and then to the skin of the woman closest to me

She's wearing a man's dress shirt completely unbuttoned

And no bra

The skin I see is her stomach and her chest

I can see her entire right breast

So I look away

Somewhat ashamed

I am forced to look at her face

It is far too thin to be healthy

A bandanna squeezes her bald head tightly

She is pale and weak from chemical or disease

Her eyes bulge like those of surprise

Her sunken face looks like that of a former beauty queen

She stares at the products as I ring them up

And I try not to stare at her small breasts every time her shirt swings open

Her friend stands behind her

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Clean and strong
Maybe she's her lover
Maybe they're related
None of the items I ring up will tell me who the friend is
They only say that the exposed woman is very ill
And bleeds from sores; wounds
She is afflicted with something
And none of these products have brand names
So she is poor
They are poor together
And about to give me their money
This woman must have cancer
I want to strike up a conversation
Something to get my mind away from this apparent mortality
Maybe she has AIDS
Maybe she shared the wrong needle with the wrong person
But every dying human looks like a junkie at some point
Her friend looks at her with worry
Cementing all my assumptions

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She is her guardian
The one who will and is watching her die
The one who will pick out her cheap coffin
The only one willing to bury her
And there is so much love between these two
I can't look at her breasts anymore
Because they'll be underground next Christmas
And that makes me shiver like it was a new thing
I am taking up way too much of their precious time
So I speed up the process and bag their stuff as quickly as possible
And I hit the total button:
Three dollars-and-sixty-seven cents in low grade medical supplies
Maybe these items will help her live another day
I should just give them to her
But that would draw attention
And I would be another person
In their lives
Reminding a living person that they are dying
and that would not be fair

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So the friend pulls out some money
The dead woman beats her to the counter
With a handful of dirty dimes
The kind collected in a cup on a street corner
Downtown dimes discarded by uptown business men
And women who aren't dying this very minute
My pity turns to anger as she picks lint out of the change on the counter
I am upset that this nice woman is so ill
but she's cracking smiles at me
with big teeth through thin lips
She knows I know
Maybe she's content
Why can't I just let her be a stranger
I watch her count the dirty dimes off the counter
But I don't count along with her
Because I want her to come up short
I take 36 dimes and try to assume some sort of apathy
But it never works
And they leave with smiles on their faces
That I couldn't have possibly given them

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and for the rest of the night I can't focus on shit
I make sure every customer after them gets a dirty dime in their change
And I try not cry for some reason
I just don't get paid enough for that sort of thing
It is 3 AM
and I am tired of trying not to care about people who don't know me

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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